

and possibly supporting the liver as well as improving resistance to infection. The seeds have been used as a mild laxative for children. A decoction of the leaves is used to treat rheumatic complaints.

Related Species Greater knapweed (*C. scabiosa*) formed part of the medieval *salve*, an ointment applied to heal wounds and to treat skin infections.

Self-help Use Conjunctivitis, p. 310.

Cephaelis ipecacuanha (Rubiaceae) Ipecac

Description Small shrub with a slender stem growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has a few oblong leaves, small white flowers, and purple-black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb grows mainly in Brazil. Cultivation has been attempted in Southeast Asia with limited success. The root of 3-year-old plants is unearthed when the plant is in flower.

Parts Used Root, rhizome.

Constituents Ipecac contains isoquinoline alkaloids, tannins, and glycosides. The alkaloids are expectorant and, at a larger dose, cause vomiting and diarrhea. They are also strongly amebicidal.

History & Folklore Ipecac came to Europe in 1672, and achieved fame as a cure for dysentery. But the cure was not without controversy. It appeared to work well in some cases but to have no effect in others. Now it is possible to see why. There are two types of dysentery—amebic and bacillary. While the herb is strongly amebicidal, it has little effect against bacilli.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though a highly effective emetic (even moderate doses of ipecac will stimulate vomiting until the contents of the stomach are cleared), it is now rarely used in conventional medicine as safer substitutes have been developed. Ipecac continues to be a common ingredient in patent over-the-counter cough medicines, as its strong expectorant action helps to clear phlegm and ease irritable coughs. It is used in the treatment of bronchitis and whooping cough. Ipecac is also still used for amebic dysentery.

! Cautions Do not use the root or rhizome. Take formulations containing ipecac carefully and only as instructed on the label. Several deaths have resulted from overdose.

Ceratonia siliqua (Fabaceae) Carob

Description Evergreen tree growing to a height of 30 ft (10 m). Has compound leaves, green flowers, and large violet-brown fruit (bean pods).

Habitat & Cultivation Native to south-eastern Europe, western Asia, and North Africa, carob flourishes in poor soil in warm temperate

climates; it is said to “want sight of the sea.” It is cultivated for its fruit, and harvested in late summer or autumn.

Parts Used Fruit, bark.

Constituents The fruit contains up to 70% sugars, fats, starch, proteins, vitamins, and tannins.

History & Folklore In ancient Egypt, carob pods were combined with porridge, honey, and wax as a remedy for diarrhea. They also featured in recipes for expelling worms, and treating poor eyesight and eye infections.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Carob pods are nutritious and, due to their high sugar content, sweet-tasting and mildly laxative. A decoction of the pulp can be used as an antidiarrheal, gently helping to cleanse and relieve irritation within the gut.



Cetraria islandica (Parmeliaceae) Iceland Moss

Description Yellow-green lichen growing in undulating, leathery tufts up to 3 in (8 cm) across.

Habitat & Cultivation Iceland moss is native to northern and alpine areas of Europe. It flourishes in sub-Arctic and mountainous regions on rocks and on the bark of trees, especially conifers. It is harvested throughout the year.

Part Used Whole plant.

Constituents Iceland moss contains lichen acids (including usnic acid) and about 50% polysaccharides. Usnic acid and the other lichen acids are powerfully antibiotic. The polysaccharides are antiviral.

History & Folklore Iceland moss has been used since ancient times as a cough remedy, and has also been used in European folk medicine as a cancer treatment.



Iceland moss is used to ease coughs and treat congestion. It also has a soothing and bitter tonic effect on the digestive tract.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Strongly demulcent, Iceland moss soothes the mucous membranes of the chest, counters congestion, and calms dry and paroxysmal coughs, being particularly helpful as a treatment for elderly people. Iceland moss is also very bitter and, within the gut, has both a demulcent and bitter tonic effect—a combination almost unique in medicinal herbs. It is thus of value in all kinds of chronic digestive problems, for instance irritable bowel syndrome.

Chamaelirium lutea (Liliaceae) Helonias, False Unicorn Root

Description Herbaceous perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m) with large, green leaves forming a basal rosette from which emerges a tall spike of green-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, helonias grows in low, moist, well-drained ground east of the Mississippi river. In view of its rarity in the wild, it is best to use alternative herbs such as black cohosh (*Cimicifuga racemosa*, p. 79) and wild yam (*Disocorea villosa*, p. 91).

Parts Used Rhizome (lifted in autumn).



Helonias root was chewed by Native American women to prevent miscarriage.

Constituents Root contains steroidal saponins (up to 9%), including chamaelirin and diogenin.

History & Folklore A traditional Native American medicine, Helonias was prized as a woman's herb and used to treat a range of gynecological problems. There is some confusion about its precise use since several herbs share the same (or similar) name.